

**Table 2**

Reasons for Having UI by Number of Episodes in 3 Months Leading to Pregnancy

|                                                                                                       | Total<br>(n = 562), % | <3 UI Episodes<br>(n = 140), % | ≥3 UI Episodes<br>(n = 422), % |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|--------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| Did not think I was going to get pregnant                                                             |                       |                                |                                |
| Any in this category                                                                                  | 42                    | 31                             | 46*                            |
| I didn't think I could get pregnant because of where I was in my cycle                                | 20                    | 19                             | 21                             |
| I didn't think I could get pregnant because I had had unprotected sex before without getting pregnant | 18                    | 10                             | 21*                            |
| I thought my partner could not get me pregnant                                                        | 8                     | 4                              | 9                              |
| I thought I was infertile                                                                             | 8                     | 4                              | 9                              |
| I thought I was too old to become pregnant                                                            | 2                     | 1                              | 2                              |
| I thought I was too young to become pregnant                                                          | 1                     | 1                              | 1                              |
| Had trouble getting a contraceptive method                                                            |                       |                                |                                |
| Any in this category                                                                                  | 40                    | 24                             | 46*                            |
| I ran out of the birth control method I was using                                                     | 20                    | 17                             | 21                             |
| I couldn't afford to pay for birth control or my insurance wouldn't cover it                          | 12                    | 4                              | 14*                            |
| I couldn't get an appointment to get birth control when I needed it                                   | 7                     | 4                              | 8                              |
| I could not get to the clinic                                                                         | 7                     | 1                              | 8*                             |
| I did not know what method to use                                                                     | 5                     | 3                              | 6                              |
| I did not want to go to a clinic or see a doctor                                                      | 4                     | 0                              | 6*                             |
| I did not know where to get a birth control method                                                    | 2                     | 0                              | 3                              |
| Wasn't planning on having sex                                                                         |                       |                                |                                |
| Any in this category                                                                                  | 38                    | 32                             | 40                             |
| I didn't think I was going to have sex                                                                | 34                    | 28                             | 36                             |
| I was using alcohol or drugs                                                                          | 7                     | 5                              | 7                              |
| I was forced to have sex                                                                              | 2                     | 2                              | 2                              |
| Worried about side effects                                                                            |                       |                                |                                |
| Any in this category                                                                                  | 34                    | 24                             | 37*                            |
| I previously had side effects from contraceptives                                                     | 17                    | 11                             | 19*                            |
| I was worried I would have a side effect                                                              | 17                    | 12                             | 19                             |
| I was worried that contraceptives were bad for my health                                              | 8                     | 6                              | 9                              |
| Partner issues                                                                                        |                       |                                |                                |
| Any in this category                                                                                  | 23                    | 14                             | 27*                            |
| My partner did not want to use birth control                                                          | 19                    | 12                             | 22*                            |
| My partner forced me to have unprotected sex                                                          | 4                     | 2                              | 5                              |
| My partner messed with my birth control.                                                              | 1                     | 0                              | 2                              |
| Contraceptives were too difficult to use                                                              |                       |                                |                                |
| Any in this category                                                                                  | 23                    | 15                             | 25*                            |
| Sometimes I forgot to use or take my birth control method                                             | 15                    | 10                             | 16                             |
| I didn't have time to use a method                                                                    | 5                     | 4                              | 5                              |
| It was difficult to insert or put on the method when I wanted to have sex.                            | 3                     | 1                              | 4                              |
| I couldn't figure out how to use the method                                                           | 2                     | 2                              | 2                              |
| Not sure if I wanted to get pregnant                                                                  |                       |                                |                                |
| Any in this category                                                                                  | 13                    | 5                              | 15*                            |
| I would have been fine either way                                                                     | 8                     | 3                              | 9*                             |
| I wanted to take the chance of getting pregnant                                                       | 6                     | 2                              | 7*                             |
| Think contraceptives don't work                                                                       |                       |                                |                                |
| Any in this category                                                                                  | 7                     | 5                              | 8                              |

\* Differences between &lt;3 episodes and ≥3 episodes are significant at an .05 level.

of women age 30 and older reported intending to have UI in the next 3 months ( $p < .05$ ; data not shown). There were no significant differences by race/ethnicity.

#### Reasons for Previous UI

Women gave an average of 2.7 specific reasons for having UI in the past 3 months. Women who had fewer than three acts of UI gave an average of 1.9 reasons; women who had more UI gave an average of 3.0 reasons ( $p < .05$ ; data not shown). The most common groups of reasons for having had UI in the 3 months before conception were that they did not think they were going to get pregnant (42%), they had trouble getting a contraceptive method (40%), and they weren't planning on having sex (38%) (Table 2). The most common specific reason was, "I did not think I was going to have sex" (34%), followed by thinking one could not become pregnant because of one's place in the menstrual cycle (20%), running out of birth control supplies (20%), and the partner not wanting to use birth control (19%). What

distinguished women who had frequent UI (three or more times in the 3-month period) from women with few reported acts was greater reporting of access problems (inability to afford, difficulty getting to the clinic, and not wanting to see a doctor), a history of side effects from contraception, a partner who did not want to use birth control, and a higher level of ambivalence about becoming pregnant.

#### Attitudes Toward UI

The most prevalent attitude about UI was that it "feels better or more natural," an opinion held by 48% of respondents. Just over one third (36%) said it was "okay to have once in a while or at certain times of the month" (Table 3). One in four women (28%), reported "relationship and partner reasons" to have UI. Although this was the least common attitude, partnership and relationship reasons to have UI were significantly associated with a willingness to have UI in the future. Among women who said they were somewhat or extremely likely to have UI in the